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MAC 101: Introduction to Mass Communication - Media, Audiences and Ethics

How messages reach millions, and who decides what counts as news

FACULTY PRIMER

Faculty Primer

Faculty of Social Sciences
Mass Communication | 100L

Written for students, by students.

Practical notes, worked examples, practice questions and a revision plan.

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Independent study support | Not an official UNIZIK publication

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Why this pack exists

Mass communication is studied as a system of institutions, technologies, audiences and effects. This pack covers the communication process, media functions and theories, news values, and the ethical and legal issues Nigerian journalists face.

This is a student-written study companion, not a reproduced lecture handout or a leaked examination paper. Use it to organise the topics you are taught, practise the kind of thinking your course rewards, and walk into class with better questions.

What you will be able to do

- Explain the communication process and the difference between interpersonal and mass communication.
- Describe the functions of the mass media and evaluate normative theories of the press.
- Apply news values to explain why one story leads and another is buried.
- Identify core ethical and legal issues in Nigerian media practice.

How to use this pack

1. Skim the whole pack once in 20 minutes so you know what is inside.
2. Work through one section at a time with your lecture note and recommended text beside you.
3. Attempt the practice questions before reading the answers. Mark what you missed.
4. Use the final checklist to plan your revision week, one tick per study session.

> **Free to download, always**
> This pack is free. There is no fee, no subscription and no payment step before download, and the full PDF is not watermarked or locked. Share the link with a coursemate instead of forwarding the file.

> **Confirm your official course outline**
> Course codes, credit units and outlines can differ by department and session. Treat this pack as supplementary support and confirm the current outline with your lecturer, course rep or departmental handbook before an assessment.

The communication process

Every communication event can be broken into components, and each component can fail.

- Sender, encoding, message, channel, noise, receiver, decoding, feedback.
- Interpersonal communication is direct and reciprocal; mass communication is mediated, public and one-to-many.
- Noise can be physical, semantic, psychological or channel-related.
- Feedback in mass communication is delayed and indirect, for example ratings or comments.
- Digital media blur the line by allowing audience participation at scale.

- A model is a simplification; use it to analyse, not to pretend reality is tidy.

Functions and theories of the press

Media do more than inform, and different societies expect different things from them.

- Functions: surveillance, interpretation, transmission of culture, socialisation, entertainment and mobilisation.
- Authoritarian theory: media serve the state.
- Libertarian theory: media should be free and open.
- Social responsibility theory: freedom carries obligations to accuracy and public interest.
- Soviet-communist and development media theories emphasise collective goals.
- Gatekeeping, agenda-setting and framing explain how media shape what audiences think about.

> **Agenda-setting versus telling you what to think**
> Media may not dictate your opinion, but they influence which issues you consider important. That distinction is examinable and worth stating precisely.

News values, ethics and law

News is a construction governed by professional routines and constraints.

- News values: timeliness, proximity, prominence, consequence, conflict, novelty and human interest.
- Ethics: accuracy, fairness, balance, privacy, avoiding plagiarism and correcting errors promptly.
- Law: defamation, contempt of court, copyright, and rules on official secrets.
- Free expression is constitutionally protected but limited by law and public interest.
- Self-regulation through codes of conduct matters where enforcement is weak.
- Digital verification, source protection and misinformation are now core professional skills.

The models that explain the field

Mass communication studies how messages reach large, dispersed audiences through media institutions. The classic transmission model - source, encoding, message, channel, noise, decoding, receiver, feedback - is useful for identifying where communication fails, but it treats meaning as something sent rather than negotiated.

The alternative is the cultural or ritual model, which treats communication as the construction of shared meaning. A broadcast does not simply deliver information; it produces a way of seeing. Understanding both models lets you analyse a news report as simultaneously a transmission of facts and a ritual reaffirming what a society treats as important.

Gatekeeping explains why some events become news and others do not. Editors, producers and platforms select, and their selection follows news values: proximity, prominence, consequence, novelty, conflict, human interest. These values are not natural; they are conventions that can be studied and criticised.